THE LAST OF KCR?

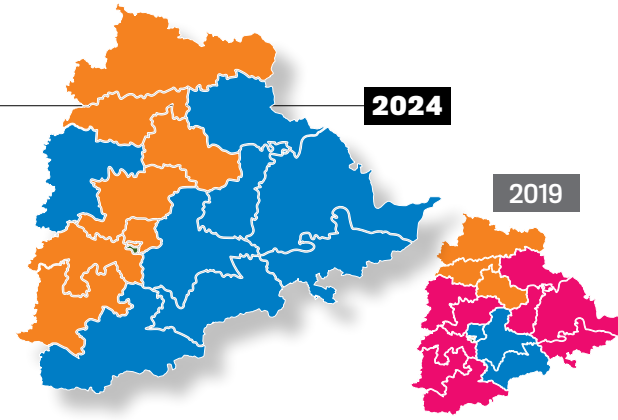
Months after losing power in the state, KCR's national ambitions also seem to have been thwarted. The BRS chief and his party now face an 'existential crisis'

By **Amarnath K. Menon**



ANI

▲ **K. CHANDRASHEKAR RAO,** *BRS president*



TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 17

	INC	BJP	BRS	AIMIM
2024	8 (40.1%)	8 (35.1%)	0 (16.7%)	1 (3%)
2019	3 (29.5%)	4 (19.5%)	9 (41.3%)	1 (2.8%)

Vote share in ( )

Chants of *'Desh ka neta KCR'*—the national leader KCR—had echoed in the Telangana Bhavan as K. Chandrashekar Rao announced the re-christening of his Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) to Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), and with it his intent to make a national foray. That was on October 5, 2022.

Now, barely six months after its drubbing in the assembly polls, yielding power to the A. Revanth Reddy-led Congress in the state, the once formidable BRS has suffered another humiliating rout in the Lok Sabha polls. The party that had won nine of the state's 17 parliamentary seats in 2019 failed to net even one seat, as its vote share plummeted to a dismal 16.7 per cent from 41.3 per cent in 2019. Conscious of the BRS's declining fortunes post the state election—a win on a third of the seats with a 37.4 per cent vote share—KCR had embarked on a frenetic bus tour, campaigning across all constituencies. But his sharp attacks on the ruling Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) proved futile, as both national parties equally split the state's seats, cornering eight each, and All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) chief Asaduddin Owaisi retained his Hyderabad bastion. The increase in the Congress's tally from three to eight saved the day for CM Reddy, who is also the party's state president. But it's the BJP that has served notice of its rise—its growth coming at the expense of the BRS and signalling the saffron party's emergence as the Congress's principal challenger.

The decline of the KCR-led BRS, which ruled Telangana for nearly a decade, is largely attributed to the former CM's own missteps. While the pioneering Rythu Bandhu scheme for farmers initially won it ardent supporters, the BRS soon became mired in a swirl of corruption allegations. KCR's attempts to stem the downward spiral bore little result, as several BRS leaders defected to the Congress and even the BJP. KCR may well struggle to retain his 39 MLAs, as the Congress—with a slim majority of 64 in the 119-strong house—seeks to bolster its strength.

BRS working president and KCR's son K.T. Rama Rao, remains defiant, claiming the party will "continue to toil" and "rise from the ashes like a Phoenix". KCR's immediate challenge is to capture power in the impending local body elections. He also has to retain the support of Backward Classes (BCs), a crucial vote bank, as other disadvantaged sections look towards the Congress. But that's a tall order, says political scientist E. Venkatesu, given the farm loan waiver and caste census promises Reddy has made. Unless the BRS develops a coherent strategy to grapple with this crisis, its downward descent will continue to be relentless. ■